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RISHABH PANT, 26

Wicketkeeper-batsman

T20s: 74, RUNS: 1,158
STRIKE RATE: 126.7
CATCHES: 40

The visuals of the wrecked, ashen car on December 31, 2022 left many dumbfounded. Lying in a pool of blood with his knee twisted out of shape and having hurt his wrist, forehead, ankle, toe and back, many wrote his epitaph as a Team India cricketer. Fourteen months later, Pant has scripted an awe-inspiring comeback, one which someday will lend itself to a documentary. Pant just had the IPL to prove that he hadn't lost his touch as a batsman and athleticism as a wicket-keeper. Captaining the Delhi Capitals, he delivered the works, both behind and in front of the stumps. With K.L. Rahul and rising star Dhruv Jurel vying for the coveted spot, Pant is aware that he has his work cut out. But here's someone who stared down death itself, ultimately doing his fair share towards winning the World Cup. That's a champion for you.



AP

AXAR PATEL, 30

All-rounder

T20s: 60, RUNS: 453, STRIKE RATE: 143.3; WICKETS: 58, ECONOMY: 7.33

This T20 World Cup has proven one thing: Axar Patel is no longer a back-up player. For long, Axar remained in the shadows of Ravindra Jadeja, but now it's clear that he has taken on Jadeja's mantle. Every time the Indian team found itself in a spot, Rohit turned to Axar, and the all-rounder didn't disappoint. Coming up in the batting order, Axar played two crucial knocks—against Pakistan in a low-scoring thriller and the 47-run knock in the final. He featured in all matches and picked up wickets on every occasion except one. In a team where not many batters bowled, and not many bowlers batted, Axar is a rarity. His ability to bowl in the powerplay, when only two fielders are allowed outside the 30-yard circle, makes him a priceless resource. He has always been a fierce competitor, but this T20 World Cup has put him in a league of his own.